Washington State Department of
CHILDREN, YOUTH & FAMILIES

Program Policy

Applies To: This policy applies to Licensing Division (LD) employees.

Chapter Number & Title: 10 Child Care Licensing
Policy Number & Title: 10.1.12 Issuing Child Care Licenses
Effective Date: October 10, 2025

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to provide guidance to LD child care employees when issuing initial and non-expiring child care licenses.

Authority

Chapter 43.216 RCW	Department of Children, Youth, and Families
WAC 110-300-0400	Application materials
WAC 110-301-0400	Application materials
WAC 110-302-0400	Application materials

Policy

1. LD child care licensors must complete the following:
    a. When processing initial licensing applications:
        i. Process the application for the appropriate license as outlined in:
            A. WAC 110-300-0400 for early learning programs.
            B. WAC 110-301-0400 for school-age programs.
            C. WAC 110-302-0400 for outdoor nature-based child care.
        ii. Follow the 6.03 Access to Services for Individuals with Disabilities policy and provide the following:
            A. Public Notice of Nondiscrimination DCYF ADM 0026 publication.
            B. ADA 504 Grievance Process DCYF ADM 0037 publication.
            C. Services for individuals with disabilities, if applicable.
        iii. Verify providers comply with the following requirements applicable to the license they are applying for prior to issuing the license, except for requirements that need children to be present:
            A. Chapter 110-300 WAC for early learning programs.
            B. Chapter 110-301 WAC for school-age programs.
            C. Chapter 110-302 WAC for outdoor nature-based programs.
        iv. Issue:
            A. The initial license for up to six months.
            B. A non-expiring license before the six-month initial license ends.

C. Up to four initial licenses. At the end of the fourth initial license either a non-expiring license or a denial must be issued.

v. Obtain approval for the:

A. First and second initial license from the supervisor.

B. Third and fourth initial license from the area administrator (AA) or designee and provide the provider with the Fair Warning Letter DCYF 15-973 form.

vi. Request one time waivers for the reapplication fee to the supervisor and AA if an applicant completed the application process within 90 days, but an external barrier out of their control exists.

vii. Accept application withdrawals prior to the initial licensure.

b. For non-expiring licenses:

i. Observe the program operation with children and:

A. The observation must include enrolled and non-household members in care.

B. Complete the appropriate initial checklist forms for the license they are applying for prior to issuing the license:

I. ONB Initial Checklist for Applicant DCYF 15-841

II. Initial Checklist for Child Care Center Applicants DCYF15-861

III. Initial Checklist for Family Home Child Care Applicants DCYF 15-862

IV. Initial Checklist for School-Age Program Applicant DCYF 15-863

ii. Conduct child care initial to non-expiring inspections:

A. For each initial license issued.

B. Within six months of the date the initial license is issued, except when approved by an AA.

iii. Complete initial to non-expiring inspections announced.

c. Review files at each initial licensure and when issuing a non-expiring license.

d. Document all notes in WA Compass within 14 calendar days.

e. Consult with supervisor for denial of applications for initial licenses.

2. Supervisors must review the:

a. First and second initial license for approval.

b. Third and fourth initial license for approval, and if approved send to the AA for their review and approval.

3. AAs must review:

a. Third and fourth initial licenses for approval.

b. Requests for one-time application fee waivers for approval.

Forms

Fair Warning Letter DCYF 15-913 (located in the Forms repository on the DCYF intranet)
Initial Checklist for Child Care Center Applicants DCYF 15-861

Initial Checklist for Family Home Child Care Applicants DCYF 15-862
Initial Checklist for School-Age Program Applicant DCYF 15-863
ONB Initial Checklist for Applicant DCYF 15-841

Resources

ADA/504 Public Notice of Discrimination DCYF ADM_0026 publication
ADA 504 Grievance Process DCYF HR_0011 publication
DCYF Administrative 6.02 Access to Services for Clients and Caregivers who are Limited English Proficient (LEP) policy
DCYF Administrative 6.03 Access to Services for Individuals with Disabilities policy
Procedures PRO10.1.12 document (located on the Licensing Division intranet, Policies, Procedures and Memos, Child Care Policies, Procedures and Tasks)
Task A TSK10.1.12A document (located on the Licensing Division intranet, Policies, Procedures and Memos, Child Care Policies, Procedures and Tasks)
Task B TSK10.1.12B document (located on the Licensing Division intranet, Policies, Procedures and Memos, Child Care Policies, Procedures and Tasks)
Task C TSK10.1.12C document (located on the Licensing Division intranet, Policies, Procedures and Memos, Child Care Policies, Procedures and Tasks)

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Approved by: Ruben Reeves, Assistant Secretary of Licensing Division